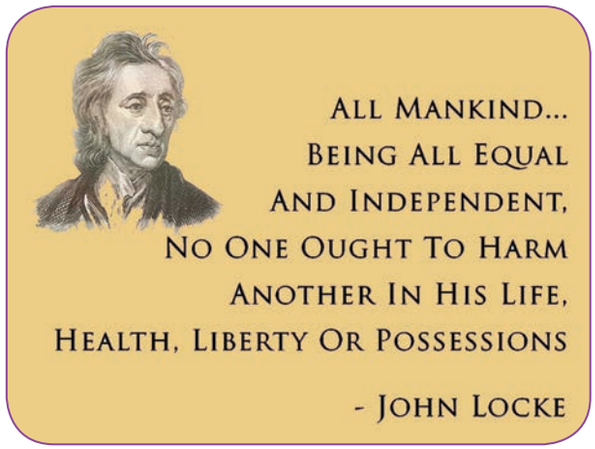
pedestrian to walk down the middle of the road, then the end of such liberty would be universal **chaos**.



Everybody would be getting in everybody else's way and nobody would get anywhere. Individual liberty would have become social **anarchy**. There is a danger of the world getting liberty-drunk in these days like the old lady with the basket, and it is just as well to remind ourselves of what the rule of the road means. It means that in order that the liberties of all may be **preserved**, the liberties of everybody must be **curtailed**. When the policeman, say, at Piccadilly Circus, steps into the middle of the road and puts out his hand, he is the symbol not of **tyranny**, but of liberty. You may not think so. You may, being in a hurry, and seeing your car pulled up by his **insolence** of office, feel that your liberty has been outraged. "How dare this fellow **interfere** with your free use of the public highway?" Then, if you are a reasonable person, you will reflect that if he did not interfere with you, he would interfere with no one, and the result would be that Piccadilly Circus would be a maelstrom that you would never cross at all. You have submitted to a curtailment of private liberty in order that you may enjoy a social order which makes your liberty a reality.

Liberty is not a personal affair only, but a social **contract**. It is an accommodation of interests. In matters which do not touch anybody else's liberty, of course, I may be as free as I like. If I choose to go down the road in a dressing- gown who shall say me nay? You have liberty to laugh at me, but I



have liberty to be **indifferent** to you. And if I have a **fancy** for dyeing my hair, or waxing my moustache (which heaven forbid), or wearing an overcoat and sandals, or going to bed late or getting up early, I shall follow my fancy and ask no man's permission. I shall not inquire of you whether I may eat mustard with my mutton. And you will not ask me whether you may follow this religion or that, whether you may prefer Ella Wheeler Wilcox to Wordsworth, or champagne to **shandy**. In all these and a thousand other details you and I please ourselves and has no one's leave.

We have a whole kingdom in which we rule alone, can do what we choose, be wise or **ridiculous**, harsh or easy, **conventional** or odd. But when we step out of that kingdom, our personal liberty of action becomes qualified by other people's liberty. I might like to practice on the trombone from midnight till three in the morning. If I went onto the top of Everest to do it, I could please myself, but if I do it in my bedroom my family will object, and if I do it out in the streets the neighbours will remind me that my liberty to blow the trombone must not interfere with their liberty to sleep in quiet.

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